

IT IS TIME TO LOOK WITHIN

TEXT: I Cor. 11:27-29 (NKJV) *“For I received from the Lord that which I also delivered to you: that the Lord Jesus on the same night in which He was betrayed took bread; ²⁴ and when He had given thanks, He broke it and said, “Take, eat; this is My body which is broken for you; do this in remembrance of Me.” ²⁵ In the same manner He also took the cup after supper, saying, “This cup is the new covenant in My blood. This do, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me.” ²⁶ For as often as you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord’s death till He comes. ²⁷ Therefore whoever eats this bread or drinks this cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of the body and blood of the Lord. ²⁸ But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread and drink of the cup. ²⁹ For he who eats and drinks in an unworthy manner eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning*

the Lord's body. ³⁰ For this reason many are weak and sick among you, and many sleep. ³¹ For if we would judge ourselves, we would not be judged. ³² But when we are judged, we are chastened by the Lord, that we may not be condemned with the world."

INTRO: There are two ordinances that we observe: Water Baptism and Communion.

Within 1500 years after that very simple beginning of our Lord's celebration of Passover with His disciples, the Lord's Table became a controversial and divisive subject in the institutional church. The following has divided us on this subject:

- There are those who teach that with each celebration of the Lord's Supper, the body of Christ is broken again and the blood of Christ is spilled again. They believe that during the act of blessing the elements at each celebration of the Eucharist, the bread

literally becomes the body of Christ and the juice/fruit of the vine literally becomes the blood of Christ. This position is called *transubstantiation*.

- Many from the Reformation argued that the Communion bread does not become the literal body of Jesus, but the body of Christ is present within the bread. And, the communion cup does not become the literal blood of the Lord, but the blood of the Lord is present within the cup. Theologians refer to this doctrine as *consubstantiation*.
- Others believe that the bread is not the physical body of Christ, and the body of Christ is also not present within the bread; the cup is not the blood of the Lord, and the blood of the Lord is not present within the cup. These reformers saw the bread and cup simply as emblems -*Symbols meant to remind participants of the Last Supper and its significance for believers throughout their earthly life.*

This debate over the elements of Communion continues today. There is further dispute among us as to whether we should eat from one loaf, or each have a separate wafer; whether we should drink from one cup, or each have a separate cup; whether we should serve communion once a week, once a month, or a couple of times a year.

It would do us well to remember that Jesus just said, “*As often as we observe this ordinance to do it in remembrance of Him*” - and what these emblems represent.

We must pay special attention to the text: 1 Corinthians 11:28 (NKJV) “***But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread and drink of the cup.***” The Message Bible says it like this, “***Examine your motives, test your heart, come to this meal in holy awe.***”

This is a command and, therefore, not to be taken lightly. When we approach the Lord's Table one of the most important exercises, we do there is self-examination, looking within.

Many times, as it pertains to our physical body, a self-examination is what brings about concern that takes us to the doctor for a professional exam. (The doctor told me, "*You should be thankful for the diverticulitis.*")

It's safe to say that no one is more familiar with our body/ mind that we are. We often know when something is not exactly right before anyone else does.

The same is true in our spiritual lives. We know something isn't right and we go to the expert, (the One who made us) to get things right.

Paul is telling these Corinthian believers, and us, to look within our lives and honestly assess our moral and spiritual condition.

Looking within affords us the opportunity to make sure that all is well and, if not, to correct it. This is much like looking into a mirror before going somewhere.

As we approach the Lords Table, we are to pray for God to reveal to us anything in our lives that is not in line with His will that would bring disgrace to Him or to us.

Looking within demands that I do three things:

- Looking at our past...
- Looking at our present...
- Looking at our future...

**LOOKING WITHIN DEMANDS THAT WE
TAKE A SERIOUS LOOK AT OUR PAST**

Take the time today to look at your past. Think of all the past failures and successes. We all have failures and successes that are a part of our past, don't we? While much of our past has the propensity to cause discouragement and even depression, we cannot afford to allow our past to dictate our present and future.

I challenge us to view our past in light of the work of the cross. Romans 8:1 (NKJV) ***“There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus, who do not walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit.”***

The conviction of the Holy Spirit in the life of the believer is a terrific thing but I want to remind us today that the Holy Spirit does not convict us of forgiven sin. That's the oppression of the enemy. God doesn't remember forgiven sin! ***“As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us.”***

As we look at our past, we must make sure that every part of our past has been brought under the blood of Jesus. We must be sure there is nothing hidden. Remember, He doesn't force His way in. We must invite Him in. This is called Looking Within.

LOOKING WITHIN DEMANDS THAT WE TAKE AN HONEST LOOK AT OUR PRESENT

We need to resolve the issues that exist between us and the Lord, before an embarrassing rooster-crowing incident makes our failures public, as it did for Peter.

Paul reminds us that if we judge ourselves, others won't have to do it for us. 1 Corinthians 11:31 (NKJV) ***"For if we would judge ourselves, we would not be judged."***

As we look within, we must be sure that everything has been brought under the blood of Jesus. We must be sure there is nothing hidden.

As we approach the Lord's Table the timing is perfect to bring those difficult spiritual and emotional issues of our lives to Christ for cleansing by His blood.

LOOKING WITHIN DEMANDS THAT WE EVALUATE OUR FUTURE

The enemy would like to convince us that our future is not all that and a bag of chips. He wants us to have a pessimistic view of the road forward, but Jesus said in John 10:10 ***“The thief has come to steal, kill and destroy. But I have come that you might have life and have it more abundantly.”***

As we celebrate at the Lord's Table today, it would do us well to remember that the bread

and the cup link us with a family of brothers and sisters in Christ, that has been growing for some 2,000 years. We are a part of something bigger than we are. (The redeemed church is a part of the church triumphant)

Being a part of the Body of Christ means that I not only have the help of the Lord available, I have the support of His Church behind me.

As I look into my future, I must remember, I have a support network that will not let me down. Philippians 4:13 ***“I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.”***

No matter how daunting our futures appear to be, we must remember, *“If the Lord is our partner, we should make our plans big.”*

CONCLUION:

As we look within to see our future, we must remember, more of this family is in heaven than

on earth at this moment. This is why the Lord said through Paul here in 1 Corinthians 11,
“For as often as you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord’s death till He comes.”

Those who have gone before us are among that ***“Great cloud of witnesses”*** where time is no more. There is no past, present, or future for them. The race is run! The battle is over! They are not in time, they are in eternity!

As we come to the Lords Table this morning we are reminded:

- Our past is gone...
- Our successes are temporary...
- Our failures have been forgotten...
- We are looking for a City...
- This world is not our home...
- The treasures of Heaven are waiting...